the Crusaders would stop off on their way to the Holy Land and conquer it, they could have the fleet.

There were a few dissenting voices, but since the alternative was going home in humiliation, the Crusaders finally agreed. Despite age and blindness, Dandolo himself accompanied them to Zadar, where a nasty siege was laid into place—despite protests from the walls that the Crusaders were attacking a Christian city, held by a king who was himself a Crusader (although King Emeric hadn't yet made a move towards the east). As a last resort, the defenders hung crucifixes from the parapets. But, encouraged by Dandolo, the Crusaders carried on with the siege until the city surrendered.[4]

By now it was nearly December, a bad time to travel by sea, and the Venetians and Crusaders decided to winter at Zadar. They divided the city in half and occupied it. Zadar was now home to over ten thousand bored, sword-carrying men, and at least one vicious armed brawl left both Venetians and Crusaders dead in the streets.

Meanwhile, young Alexius's sister Irene had "beseeched her husband Philip of Germany to do his utmost to succor her father . . . and to help her brother, who was homeless and without a country and wandered about like the planets." Philip was very willing to do so. Pope Innocent III had refused to crown Philip as Holy Roman Emperor, instead declaring his rival Otto be the emperor elect. Now Philip was being asked to help restore the rights of another Christian emperor; removing a usurper from the throne of Constantinople would certainly show Philip to be fulfilling the role of Holy Roman Emperor, no matter what the pope said.[5]

As he was unwilling to leave Germany open to Otto, Philip himself couldn't go to Jerusalem. Instead, he and young Alexius concocted a plan: they would send envoys to the Crusaders at Zadar and ask them to help Alexius get the throne back. "Since you are on the march in the service of God, and for right and justice," Philip wrote, "it is your duty . . . to restore their possessions to those who have been wrongfully dispossessed." More concrete incentives were offered as well; Alexius was promising ten thousand men and 200,000 silver marks, which would solve all of the financial troubles of the Fourth Crusade.[6]

The Crusaders did not embrace this deal at once; in fact, they divided into three parties. One was all for marching to Constantinople, since this gave the entire Crusade the best chance of success. A second group insisted on going straight to the Holy Land. The third lobbied for going to Egypt first and attacking the sultan who controlled Jerusalem before tackling the city itself.

Eventually, the Constantinople party won the day. But the arguments continued all winter. "I can assure you," writes Villehardouin, "that the hearts